

with an overview of how it is treating its aficionados and connoisseurs.

## FINDING A FIRM FOOTING

According to a Nasscom report, India, with 1.3 billion people and two-thirds below the age of 35, the world's largest youth population, is now poised to become one of the world's leading markets when it comes to gaming. Traditionally, games did not have a foothold in India due to a lack of access to gaming consoles and PCs, and the low social acceptance of this entertainment medium. The past few years changed all of this and the Indian gaming industry is now at the cusp of a major transformation. E-sports are the newest in-thing. Reasons for this are legion.

As Chandrahas Panigrahi, Senior Director and Consumer Business Head, Acer India puts it, "It is true that globally, the gaming industry is taken way more seriously than in India. But LAN gaming has now evolved and become more competitive than ever before here. We have been coming across events like the Taiwan Excellence Gaming Cup that have become such a rage. In countries such as South Korea, gaming is truly a passion, with eSports tournaments being welcomed and played with utmost dedication. In India, too there certainly is a change in the attitude towards gaming. There is increased acceptance from parents and society in general towards professional/competitive gaming now."

Panigrahi has a point because as is evident, economic growth in India is now responsible for the genesis of a society that is embracing digital content and entertainment like never before, enabled by an implosion of smartphones and affordable internet facilities.

## GAMING TOGETHER

It is a known fact that in countries such as the US, Japan and South Korea, e-sports has become a profession for many. With several tournaments and contests doing the rounds of gaming circuits, it also means gamers earn big bucks by playing professionally. A popular gaming tournament recently came in the news for awarding the biggest prize pool in the history of e-sports, at over \$18 million. In India too, several players are interested in competitive games. About 61 per cent of the online gaming community in India plays Dota 2, about 27 per cent players play Counter strike and 19 per cent of the players play Team Fortress. There is also a bevy of youngsters who love to play Counter Strike or Dota.

In fact, Panigrahi points out that the spurt in the growth of the gaming industry is suddenly so seminal that it has given rise to a faction of



gamers who get together to collaborate collectively. He says, "The interest in gaming has increased significantly in India over the last couple of years. So much so that an interesting development in the gaming industry would be the fact that a gaming industry forum was born in 2010 with a vision to help India become a hub for gaming, to better the industry-government collaboration and interface, and increase international access and outreach."

The Gaming Forum consists of five active city chapters – Mumbai, Delhi, Hyderabad, Pune and Bangalore – each of which hosts developer meet-ups on a regular basis. It also arranges the annual NASSCOM Game Developers Conference – a premier industry event in India.

## A 'VIRTUALLY' BRIGHT FUTURE

While LAN gaming has its own story to tell, mobile gaming is definitely going places mainly because these games can be played by anyone at any time, provided they have access to the internet. Many credit the 'virtual reality' for increasing the popularity of gaming in most countries, India being no exception. Virtual reality as its theoretical definition goes is a computer technology that uses software-generated realistic images, sounds and sensations to replicate a real environment or an imaginary setting, and simulates a user's physical presence in this environment to enable him or her to interact with this space.

The concept of virtual reality has found several takers over the years, not just among gamers but also among the audience who go to watch tournaments. Like most other gaming events, Taiwan Excellence Gaming Cup has always been streamed live on Twitch TV as well as is thronged by fans who want to witness the battle themselves. This year, we experienced higher footfall at the event only proving the point that a growing audience and virtual reality together are the gaming